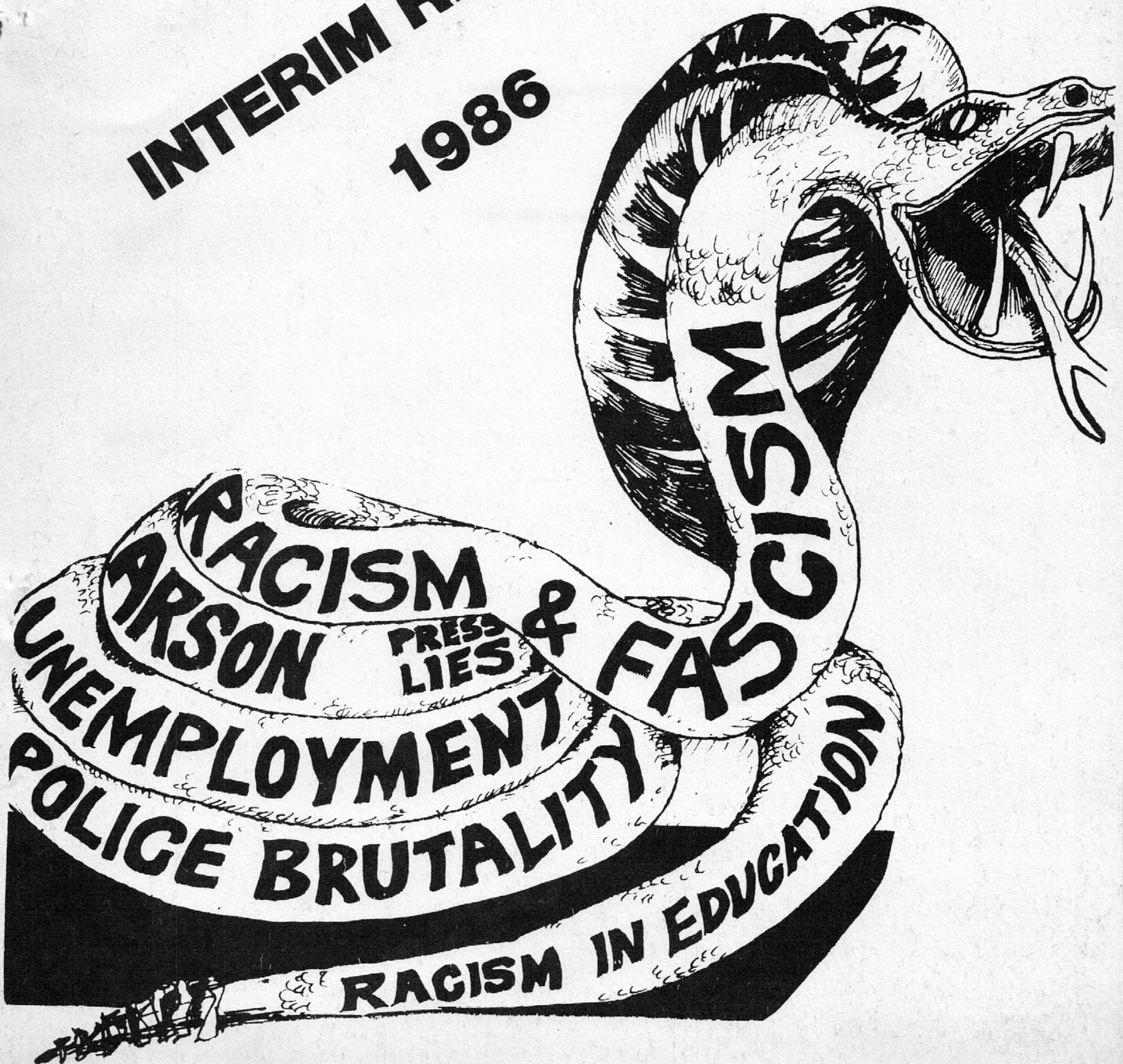
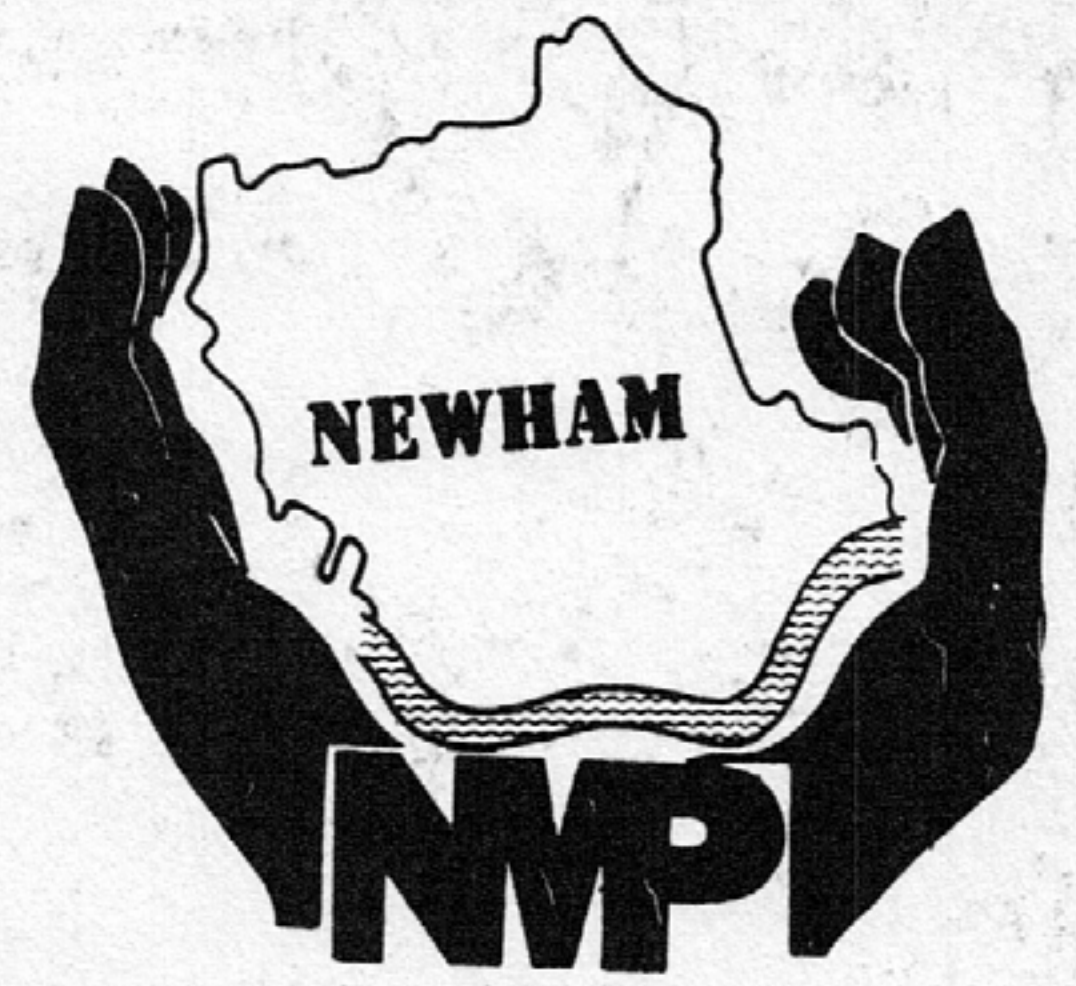


**NEWHAM
MONITORING
PROJECT
INTERIM REPORT
1986**



INTRODUCTION

1986 has not only been critical for Newham Monitoring Project, but for all groups and individuals working in the community playing their part in combating racial attacks on black people. The increasing savagery of the attacks reported in 1985 continues relentlessly, particularly in the E16 area, and is reflected by the series of arson attacks in E6.

The police themselves have stated that Newham has the highest number of racial attacks in London, and has now targeted Newham and Ealing Boroughs for a pilot police scheme to combat racial attacks, and for building up their recruitment of black police officers. The gimmicks of a few advertising posters, and press conferences expressing 'concern' is not going to address the serious and fundamental questions concerning the abysmal response by the police to racial attacks, or their treatment of black people in custody.

From where we stand, one of the most sinister and frightening developments has been consistent attack upon the Tamil community both locally and nationally. Nationally, the limited rights of representation that exist under the Immigration laws have been severely curtailed, rendering MP's virtually helpless. The hysterical reporting in the media, particularly the press, about Tamils seeking political asylum has further fuelled anti Tamil sentiments.

We cannot avoid the fact that the increasing attacks upon Tamils and other black people resident in Newham is partly due to this kind of reporting. In November 1986 an horrific arson attack took place in Burges Road, East Ham in which three Tamils lost their lives. The police response from the very beginning was to view this attack as politically motivated between various political groups within the Tamil community, five Tamils were later to be arrested and charged. In our full report we will be detailing the nature of the police response to this and the other arson attacks in Burges Road, the analysis of which gives a disturbing picture of indifference, and hostility towards Tamils and other members of the black community in Burges Road.

In March 1986 Newham Council took positive and practical decision in its stand against racial attacks by agreeing to provide funding for Newham Monitoring Project after the abolition of the Greater London Council. We hope that this commitment is maintained.

This interim report describes some of our work during 1986, and emphasises the need for NMP and other local organisations to continue challenging the increasing attacks on black people.

CASEWORK

There is no doubt that casework forms the most important part of our work, enabling us to provide a more complete picture of racial and police harassment in the borough and allowing us to effectively monitor the response of statutory agencies.

We have always acted from the point of view of the person complaining of harassment and in 1986 we continued to do so. This ensures that our casework remains very much guided by the needs and wishes of the local people who use our services and in this way we have worked more efficiently to try and solve the difficulties they face.

In 1986, 345 cases were brought to our notice, and they were classified as follows:

Racial Harassment	221	(64%)
Police Harassment	98	(28%)
Others	26	(8%)
	345	(100%)

At first sight this might seem like a slight increase of 13% on 1985's figures. However, if we exclude from last year's figures the cases brought to our attention through the Newham 7 Defence Campaign, this represents a real increase in our case-load of 53% on last year. We should also point out the fact that the figures would be substantially higher, had we included the numerous repeated attacks on individual families during the year. In addition we must stress that our figures only represent a small fraction of what we believe is actually occurring in the Borough.

If we take all of this into account it is clear to see that our work has expanded vastly over the year. It is also poignant to note that in the three year period 1984-1986 our racial harassment case-load has more than doubled as has our casework generally, and today we still only have the same number of full-time workers.

The largest number of racial harassment incidents still occur on council estates, although during the year we had more and more cases referred to us which involved owner occupiers or tenants in private accommodation.

In all racial harassment cases our role has been to:

- (i) Adequately support and advise the victim.
- (ii) Bring as much pressure to bear on the police to try and ensure that they act responsively, arrest the perpetrator and bring the most severe charges.
- (iii) Pressurise the other statutory agencies to meet their responsibilities to local black people whether they are council tenants or not.

During 1986 we have further drawn on the help of the other local voluntary organisations, and the intervention of councillors and MP's in order to safe-guard the possibility that cases be handled satisfactorily by the police and local council.

In cases of police harassment our role is to:-

- (i) Try and secure the release of a detained person as soon as possible, or if this is not possible to make sure they are legally represented.
- (ii) Make sure that those involved receive proper legal advice from a sympathetic solicitor.
- (iii) Ensure that people who sustain injuries during police detention receive immediate medical attention, once released from custody.
- (iv) See that any necessary photographs are taken of injuries incurred while in police custody.
- (v) Make formal complaints on behalf of the victim.
- (vi) Pressurise council officers, councillors, MP's etc. to investigate police malpractices with the view to making sure that officers who perpetrate racist behaviour and beat up black people are more adequately dealt with.

Referrals

This year we received a higher number of referrals, compared to 1985, came from the use of our 24-hour emergency service. The majority of our cases were however brought to our attention either from people visiting our offices directly or from other sources.

Direct Appointments	64
24hr Emergency Service (Night Line only)	85
Others(advice agencies, NISAS,housing dept.etc)	196

The Emergency Service

1986 has seen a considerable rise in the use of our emergency service telephone number. This increase in the use of the service, particularly during the night, has been partly due to the greater emphasis that we have placed on outreach work over the year. We have done a variety of talks to schools, youth clubs, unemployed centres, built upon our liaison with other voluntary groups and encouraged a greater circulation of our emergency service literature - especially bust cards displaying the emergency number.

Quite the opposite to the rise in emergency service calls has been the decline in the number of volunteers we have running the service. At one stage during the year the number of volunteers was reduced by nearly a half, putting additional pressure on the full-time workers, and the remaining volunteers. However, we managed to survive and during the later part of the year put more emphasis on advertising for new volunteers and holding regular training sessions all of which will be continued into the new year.

We feel that it is essential to keep our volunteers up-to-date with the legislation particularly governing "stop and search" arrests and raids and to ensure this we organised two weekend training sessions, for our volunteers using the services of David James, a solicitor, on the Police and Criminal Evidence Act 1984. Further training sessions are to be held in the new year, as will sessions on the new public order legislation.

To make the volunteer's job easier we have reviewed the second part of their hand-book and extended the network of contacts, interpreters and solicitors for cases of emergency. Presently, the legal side of the hand-book is being revised by David James, and should be ready early in 1987.

Despite the fall in the number of emergency service volunteers, we still maintain a high level of involvement by local people who are committed to helping us with the day to day running of the Project. We are forever inundated with requests to have student placements and provide voluntary work mainly for young people. We hope that during the new year this enthusiasm to participate in the work of the Project will very much continue.

RACIAL HARASSMENT

1986 continued the ever increasing pattern of violent physical attacks on black people in Newham. It is far from exaggeration to say that the majority of racial harassment incidents we have monitored over the year have involved physical attacks, ranging from stoning and assault to stabbing and arson. It is a pattern which came to public attention in Newham with the murder of Akhtar Ali Baig in 1980, and has made a firm imprint on the lives of black people, in the borough, ever since.

Our work over the year reflects even more so than previously that black people are not safe in their homes, or when they walk any of the streets in the borough. Black children are not safe when travelling to and from schools or social centres. Black people are not safe when they go shopping, or travel to pick up their children from nurseries or schools. We are still barred from a number of pubs, community centres and clubs in the area because of the unwritten rule that "blacks are not allowed". In 1986, some of us either through ignorance or bravery have paid the price of abandoning the rules of "white law" in this borough, and consequently have the scars or convictions to prove it.

"No Blacks" - Council Estates Worsen

Excluding the 71 reported incidents, the majority of cases we have handled still come from council tenants, and council tenants are often identified as or suspected to be the perpetrators.

Figures:	Attacks on Council Tenants	-	91
	Attacks on People in Private Accommodation	-	21
	Attacks on the Street, Pubs, Schools etc.	-	38

From our figures there is no question that the worst areas of the borough for racial harassment, despite the existence of the council's policy, include Canning Town, Plaistow, Manor Park, West Ham and some parts of Stratford. All the estates we mentioned last year, Rathbone, Warrior Square, Memorial Avenue etc. still remain as major a problem as ever.

In a year when we would expect some considerable improvement, the response of the council has instead been patchy and hap-hazard. Indeed, generally the council has failed to co-ordinate its response to the problem of racial harassment and we still await departments like Housing, Social Services and Leisure Services to seriously start working together.

As far as the housing department is concerned, from our case-studies, it is apparent that the area one lives in very much determines the type of service and response one receives after reporting racial harassment. If you live in an area, where your district office has some sympathetic housing officers you will receive a better service than if you do not. Some district offices, have given the appearance of being very organised while others, the large majority, are simply unwilling to respond effectively to racist attacks or are still unsure how to deal with them.

In 1986, the housing department has generally remained insensitive when allocating properties to vulnerable black families. On numerous occasions officers have persisted in housing people in properties vacated by other black people because of harassment. They have also persisted in housing black families in areas where harassment of black neighbours is an everyday occurrence, and where families are bound to lack support and security.

Mr and Mrs A moved into the southern part of E6 early in the year, to a fairly new property, which well suited their needs and those of their four very young children (ages 8yrs, 5yrs, 4yrs, and 1yr old). Although they were not transferred for this reason the family had been subjected to racial harassment in the area they moved from.

In their new home they were the only Asian family on the road, or in the immediate area. They had been housed fairly close to known fascists and in an area where fascist activity was rife. As a consequence they suffered considerable racist abuse, particularly from teenagers in the area. Mrs A. was assaulted by three teenage girls who made it clear that they did not want Asians living in the area, and later by the mother of one of the girls to whom she had complained.

Despite the identity of the perpetrators being known and the fact that there were independent witnesses to many of the attacks - the police did nothing. The family should have been under police protection, but instead they were under surveillance by one of Newham's leading NF activists. The final straw came when some white men drove up in a car and threw a can of paint all over the front of the house and daubed fascist and racist slogans in it. The couple were driven out of their "ideal" home and into another part of the borough.

Although there is no doubt that the police mishandled this case totally, we also feel that the council should not have placed a family with such very young children in a position where their safety would be very much in jeopardy. This the council could have assessed through an examination of the area, its history and present inhabitants. Even though the physical injury to the family was not as major as it could have been, the mental scar and torment which results from living under such conditions will always remain with them.

This is not the only worrying aspect of the "patchy" allocations policy, which has been illuminated by our casework over the last year. In 1985, we reported the appalling treatment of disabled tenants and single black women by the housing department, and certainly for both these sections of the community our casework shows that things have altered very little. However, what is also apparent is the willingness with which the housing department exploits desperate homeless families and places them in a position where they are likely to be subject to vicious racist attacks, completely unsupported. Notably, this has particularly involved families who may be new to the borough, and sometimes new to the country, thus, they have no understanding of how the system works, and are easy targets for exploitation.

Mr and Mrs B were newly married. After their marriage they lived in private rented accommodation, but were eventually forced to leave. The first property that they were offered by the council was in E16, but they turned it down for fears about the area. Yet, the council's second offer was also in E16, and this time for fear that they would be offered nothing else they accepted. Within three months of moving in all windows in their flat had been broken. In addition, Mrs B was always abused when she used the nearby phone-box, and late at night youths would continuously bang on the front door shouting abuse. Mrs B suffered her first miscarriage because of the stress that she was living under. The housing department, despite the pleas of the District Race Equality Officer, did nothing to alleviate the couple's fear and distress. Mrs B suffered a second miscarriage, which could quite clearly have been avoided, and only then did the housing department agree to move them to a "safer" area.

A case where we were successful in preventing the sort of council negligence exemplified above involved a family who had recently arrived in the country and had been living in bed and breakfast accommodation for a considerable length of time, before being offered a property in E16. They knew nothing about the history of the area and because of desperation would have probably accepted the dwelling had we not intervened. The property was situated in a road, adjoining another road where an Asian family had almost died from a serious arson attack previously in the year. There was wide publicity about the arson, the extent of harassment in the area was known yet the housing department were prepared to be responsible for subjecting another family to a life of horror. Through our highlighting of the extent of harassment in the area, and representations made by other organisations, the offer was withdrawn and the family were offered a property in an area of the borough which has a "safer" reputation.

South Newham

The E16 area, particularly Canning Town, has unquestionably been of most concern during the year. Some of the most horrific attacks that we have documented have occurred here.

On the way back to school, from a games lesson in the middle of the afternoon Mr C (15 years old) was walking near the under-pass at Rathbone market with 4/5 other school children. A white man walked pass them with a drink in his hand. He was approximately in his early twenties. He threw the drink in Mr C's face, then pulled a knife and slashed him across the face. The teacher, chased the man for a little while but was unable to catch him. Mr C was taken to hospital by the teacher, who also informed the police of the incident, he required several stitches to his face. The police did not report the incident to Mr C's parents, Thankfully the hospital did. Nearly a month after the incident a statement still had not been taken from Mr C by the police. Consequently to date no-one has been arrested and charged.

The problem of racial harassment in E16 has clearly slipped out of control by the council departments during the past year, particularly as they are unsupported by the local police. This is reflected in the number of unsolved attacks in the area over the year. To some extent the attacks have been clearly organised as for example in the Star Lane/Croydon Road area where shops, shopkeepers and residents have been under persistent attack. On one property alone the following incidents occurred

August	'86	-	Petrol bomb thrown at the premises.
September	'86	-	Smoke bomb placed inside the premises causing nominal damage to the floor covering.
September	'86	-	A window broken
September	'86	-	A window broken
September	'86	-	A window broken
October	'86	-	Theft of a till
November	'86	-	Assault on staff at the venue

An Asian man and his son, left the shop, and were returning to their parked car. They were attacked by 15-20 white men and women, some of whom had come out of Raffles Wine Bar on the Barking Road. The Asian man had beer poured over him, suffered cuts to his face from a broken pint glass, and long term injuries to his back and legs. His son suffered cuts, bruises, and a broken arm. The police have arrested only 4 of the people responsible, despite knowing the identity and whereabouts of many of the others responsible.

In addition to these, more recent incidents in the area include:

- An Afro-Caribbean youth being stabbed.
- An Afro-Caribbean shop owner having ammonia squirted in his eyes. He was nearly blinded and spent 5 days in hospital.
- An air-riffle being fired through the window of an Indian restaurant.

A group of youths, some of whom are members of the 'Croydon Road Gang' are suspected of being responsible for many of the attacks yet, the number of arrests for all the above incidents have been negligible. People in the area now have no confidence whatsoever that the police will maintain their safety.

Burges Road

Much attention has been focused on Canning Town and the South of the Borough as areas notorious for racial attacks. However, other parts of Newham, particularly the area around Burges Road in East Ham, have seen a frightening escalation in the number of racial attacks over the past year. This phenomena is particularly worrying because of the large proportion of black people in this part of the Borough - an area which ought to be 'relatively safe'.

Families and school children have been subjected to attacks with weapons including phosphorous bombs and an ammonia gun which were used by individuals from a moving car. Most alarming however, has been the number of arson attacks - five in all - which have taken place in Burges Road within a period of six months during 1986.

The most tragic incident took place on November 14th which resulted in the deaths of three Asian men. In comparison to the other five attacks the police were swift in their response to immediately vilify, persecute and arrest members of the black community. In particular, the Tamil population within the area were singled out and targeted for harassment from the police. On the weekend of the 14th/15th November one MP alone received over 32 calls from members of the Tamil community who had been arrested by the police on the pretext of their immigration status. Within hours of this attack a very large police presence was drafted into the area.

A protest picket outside East Ham police station, attended by local people, was held in order to bring pressure on the police to examine thoroughly whether the attack was racially motivated. The police throughout that day informed local shopkeepers to board up their shops because there was going to be a riot that night!

In none of the other arson attacks have any of the perpetrators been charged or arrested despite extensive community pressure. The police have consistently failed to provide any information on the attacks or report on the progress of their investigations. They have also refused to investigate known racists and fascists in the area.

At a public meeting held in East Ham during October which was attended by local residents and other concerned individuals, further information concerning police indifference to the fire bombing of a local black family came to light. On the day of the attack, police had questioned neighbours suggesting that the attack was due to 'inter-racial problems' in the road. The following day officers suggested that the attack was the result of problems with 'arranged marriages'.

As a result of public concern about the worsening situation in the area, and community pressure on the police, Newham Council agreed to fund a temporary advice unit in St. Pauls Church, Burges Road, from 1 January 1987 - 31 March 1987. Its main aim will be to investigate and determine in much more detail the nature and extent of racial harassment of black people in the immediate area, and to make known other groups offering advice and support.

Where Can Black People Go?

Attacks on the street remain a considerable problem, and racists still persist in getting away with assaulting black people in broad day-light without being apprehended.

Mr D a middle-aged Afro-Caribbean man was walking along the road where he lived, in Manor Park, towards his home. Two white men were walking on the other side of the road in the opposite direction. They crossed over the road, walked up to Mr D, called him a "black bastard", and punched him to the ground. They then kicked him all over including on the head and in the eyes. Finally, one of them jumped on Mr D's face and he was knocked unconscious. The attackers have not been caught.

Similar to street attacks, some pubs also remain a haven from which racists can perpetrate attacks and go unnoticed, as in the case of Raffles Wine Bar. The Avenue pub in E12 has also been brought to our notice.

In the new year we shall be stepping up the pressure on the breweries responsible for these establishments, in the hope that they may be able to force the land-lords to responsibly deal with customers who perpetrate attacks either on their premises or in the immediate vicinity of the premises.

Attacks By School Children

In 1986 attacks on black people were carried out by children as young as 7 or 8 years old. Many women have complained that they have been spat at or stoned by such children and their babies and young children physically assaulted before their own eyes. The women have felt helpless to do anything because the perpetrators are so young, and for fear that the law will work against them.

Mr E came to England for a holiday to visit his son and daughter-in-law. One day while returning from the nursery after picking up his grand-child, he was shot in the eye with an air-riffle. The pellet damaged the eye totally and Mr E returned to his home country half blind. The youth who had shot Mr E with the air riffle, was only seventeen years old.

Attacks around schools have not been reported to the same extent as last year, and this may be because some schools, like Langdon for example, have taken positive steps over the year to stem the level of racial violence perpetrated by its pupils. However, such schools should not be complacent and we are sure that we still do not hear about the majority of attacks occurring around schools.

Women and Racial Harassment

As we have already pointed out the council have remained insensitive to the needs of black women during the year. This despite, as we said last year, the fact that women are most vulnerable to racist attacks, especially if they live alone with young children.

Over the year we have documented a number of incidents where organised racist activity was particularly aimed at single black women. Such cases include that of an Asian Women, Ms I whose boyfriend was Afro-Caribbean. She lived alone with her children in E6. Soon after she moved in she started receiving letters signed by the National Front threatening to burn her out. All letters were passed to the police. No one was ever arrested and the woman was transferred.

In E16 the situation is very bad, and between November 1985, and August 1986 3 single black women and their families were transferred from Fords Park Road, to other parts of the borough. No one has been prosecuted for the harassment they caused to the families, and the housing department have not even begun to tackle the racists who clearly live in the area. Many other cases have occurred in E16 about which the housing department have done nothing but transfer the women.

Ms J had lived in her accommodation for over 3 years when the harassment started. She received threatening letters and had NF graffiti sprayed onto her front door, and scratched onto the door. She also received abusive phone calls, had excreta and sand put through the letterbox. One day, when she was at work, her flat was broken into and a thick black arrow was sprayed onto her front door to the lounge where the words "WOGS OUT" had been sprayed round the room in gigantic letters. After this, Ms J and her young daughter spent some weeks sleeping on the floor at a friend's house before being rehoused.

In the above mentioned case the housing department were very slow to act, and could have put Ms J out of her misery long before things worsened. Instead, every time she reported a new incident of harassment she was told that there was nothing the housing department could do. This case is not isolated, and we have had many more complaints from women who feel that they are patronised or treated flippant, by housing officers, when they try to report their case, as well as by the police.

We are extremely critical of the council and the fact that despite evidence to prove the special needs of women, no provision has been made for temporary refuge or shelter once the harassment becomes intolerable and women are forced to leave their homes involuntarily. Without making such provision, the

council do, however, still persist in forcing single women, some of whom are not confident when speaking English, to live on all white estates where they are seen as easy targets for racists. Some Asian women visit our offices, frustrated at the fact that they live alone on estates. They have no friends and because of their nervousness about speaking English cannot answer back when they are spat at or racially abused. The council's answer to all of this has been to transfer women, only after the situation has reached dangerous proportions, and in doing this they still sometimes move women from one vulnerable position to another.

A small group of women who have suffered racial harassment have been working with us to try and set up a group specifically designed to meet the needs of women like themselves, and support each other. The group will also give many women the opportunity to adequately voice their concerns and demands to the council and the police. Already, many more women have expressed an interest to be involved and the group will launch itself in the new year.

The Police Response - No Move Forward

We have all got used to the rhetoric of senior police officers regarding their commitment to deal with racial harassment. A rhetoric which now falls on deaf ears because of black people's very bitter experiences.

Last year, as we reported, Commissioner Newman made racist attacks a priority and this sentiment has been re-iterated during 1986. It has, however, not filtered down to the senior and beat officers of "K" division - many of whom cannot define racial harassment, let alone tackle it.

Of all the cases we actually handled our figures show that the police only took action in 8% of cases, thus in 92% of cases no action was taken.

Our casework in 1986 reveals many of the same criticisms of the police that we have always maintained, and they include the following:-

- (1) The failure to respond quickly to attacks, if at all. Eg, an Asian family in E12 reported an attempted arson. The police initially refused to visit the family straight away because they were unable to identify the perpetrators. It was only after further calls to the police station and desperate pleas for assistance that the police responded.
- (2) The flippancy with which they deal with the victims when they do respond, coupled with racist abuse.
- (3) The negligence with which they follow up investigations.

(4) The failure to bring the correct charges that the attack has warranted in order to deter further attacks.

(5) The failure to ensure that the Crown Prosecution Service has sufficient evidence to pursue a prosecution with vigour.

In many cases we have not even noted a pretence to be efficient. Fewer people have this year reported that the police have advised them to take out private prosecutions, as was the pattern last year - they simply did nothing. However, similar to last year is the fact that police officers never fail to use an opportunity to criminalise innocent black people who have been the victims of racial harassment.

Mr G and his brother Mr H went for a quiet drink in their local pub. They had never drank in the pub before, but when they went in they felt considerable hostility. One of the brothers wanted to leave but the other said they should stay for a quick drink. They had not sat down for long, before two white men began harassing them. The brothers spoke to the barman but it did no good. They also tried to leave by the door they had come in by, but were prevented from doing so by the white men. Eventually, they spoke to the manageress who allowed them to leave through the bar. When they got outside eight white men were waiting for them. Both brothers were beaten up and suffered many cuts and bruises. The police arrived on the scene and without trying to find out what had happened they arrested the two Asian brothers, and charged them with threatening behaviour. Only one of the white men was also charged, with threatening behaviour. The Asian brothers were bound over to keep the peace for six months.

We have been continuously frustrated by the absence of any will on behalf of the police, and some housing officers have also clearly found them to be obstructive. For this reason glossy new ventures adopted by the police in 1987 will not blind black people to the real fact that the policing of racist attacks is virtually non-existent.

POLICE HARASSMENT

Following the disorders in Tottenham in 1985, 1986 was the year which saw the police designate areas in Newham such as Little Ilford and parts of Forest Gate as possible riot areas and have subsequently subjected these areas to a high level of surveillance. District Support Units and surveillance teams have been operational in these areas for the whole of 1986.

Although our figures for police harassment show a slight fall in comparison to last year, this is a deceptive representation. The 1985 figures were high because of 79 arrests resulting from two Newham 7 Defence Campaign marches and pickets. In total there were 98 cases of police harassment reported to the Project in 1986.

Charged with an offence	68 (69%)
Released without charges	12 (12%)
Result unknown & other types of harassment	18 (19%)
	98 (100%)

Of the 68 charged, examination of the figures shows:

Guilty	23 (34%)
Not Guilty	12 (18%)
Cases pending	10 (15%)
Cautioned	7 (10%)
Bound over	1 (1%)
Charges dropped	12 (18%)
Result unknown	3 (4%)
	68 (100%)

There is a heavy concentration of police activity in and around Forest Gate. Of the 98 police harassment cases, 41 (42%) of these were in this area reflecting the kind of surveillance which black people have been under, particularly in Upton Lane. The police have made concerted attempts to marginalise the predominately young Afro-Caribbean youths in the area.

The nature of harassment can be seen in the figures below:

Stop and search	22
Home raided	27
Racist Language	39
Physical assault	31
Passport checks	3
Strip search	2
Snatch squad arrest	4
Sexual assault	1

129*

* in some cases of police harassment victims have suffered more than one type of police harassment.

Over the year we have dealt with an increasing number of assaults by police officers on black people, for which the officers involved are never disciplined or prosecuted. However the victims of such harassment nearly always find themselves charged with assaulting the officer who perpetrated the attack against them. In such cases our role has been to gain the best possible legal defence for the person involved, and pursue legal action against the police officers.

The police are clearly indiscriminate when it comes to harassing black people, and this is exemplified by one of the cases brought to our notice, which involves a young afro-caribbean girl (sixteen years old). After leaving her friend's house in the Romford Road one evening, she was dragged into Forest Gate police station, sexually assaulted, and beaten up by six male police officers. One of them rolled ink over her face and clothes, saying 'here's your war paint nigger', and they continually hurled racist abuse at her. She was so badly injured in the station that she suffered internal injuries, and consequently may not be able to have children in the future. After all this she was charged with assaulting two of the police officers, and threatening behaviour. This case is pending, and we are attempting to prosecute the officers responsible.

Forest Gate

The policies of 'stop and search', 'snatch squads', patrolling District Support Units, and home raids are most prevalent in the Forest Gate area. In March, following the arrest of Mr. M members of the black community in the area were outraged at yet another arrest of an innocent person.

In response a delegation to Forest Gate Police Station was organised to show the police the strength of feeling against their policing of the area. The delegation met senior police officers for about an hour. Following a small peaceful demonstration outside Forest Gate Police Station, police officers provoked conflict by blocking the entrance to a near-by record shop where most of the people were going. This led to ten arrests, which involved individual charges ranging from obstruction to actual bodily harm.

It later became known that the police were suggesting that Mr M. had drugs in his possession. However, it was also known that what ever the substances were, the police had found these on the floor in the police station and were trying to link this to Mr. M. Local people were sure that a frame up was taking place, and such was their concern that a meeting was called the following day attended by about 50 people, comprising of those who had been arrested, their friends, representatives of community organisations and Borough councillors. The meeting elected a smaller group, and it was decided that the local MP should also be included although he was not present, to demand an explanation from higher ranking police officers.

This second meeting with the police - who not only arrived 45 minutes late, but attempted to dictate the composition of the delegation - uncovered the fact that the police were now unsure about the nature of the substance they claimed to have been possessed by Mr M. The local MP demanded that the police give those present the identity of the substance. However the police claimed that they could not, one of the excuses being that it had been destroyed during the testing process! They were also questioned by the Chair of the council's Police Committee Support Unit about the spreading of riot rumours amongst shopkeepers in Green Street by police officers.

The following weekend (a bank holiday weekend) the police drafted in a number of extra units, alleging that there was to be a riot in the Forest Gate area. We saw this as another deliberate attempt to create tension in the area. Working with local groups we were able to alert people to what was happening and monitor the situation closely over the four days.

Success

Mr. F

In February Mr.F was arrested in Plaistow for allegedly assaulting a police officer. Mr.F was running along Baalam Street, because he had to keep an urgent appointment. A police officer on the other side of the road, stopped him and asked him why he was running. When Mr.F objected to being held by the officer, he radioed for help, referring to Mr.F as a 'stroppy case'.

Mr.F was bundled into the back of a metro, but asked to be transferred to a transit van because an officer was sitting on top of him. To arrest Mr. F the police used a metro, a rover and a transit van with eight police officers. A police helicopter was also deployed. Mr.F was charged with assaulting a police officer in the execution of his duty.

Mr.F was found not guilty in court on the grounds that they could not provide an adequate reason for stopping him in the first place.

Unfortunately Mr.F is one of the few black people to be found not guilty on such charges. On most similar occasions the judges believe the evidence of the officer as opposed to the victim.

Ms. S.

Ms.S was driving her car in Forest Gate when she was confronted by a white woman. She was racially abused and attacked by the white woman and in response she defended herself. When the police arrived Ms.S was arrested and charged with assaulting the white woman.

In the court case much of the evidence against Ms.S could not be substantiated, and she was found not guilty.

Mr.P

Mr.P had gone to Selfridges as part of a young unemployed people's exchange organised with the assistance of a local community centre. The previous week he had gone to France as part of this exchange, therefore the following week it was his turn to show the French people around London. He was standing outside the shop when officers arrested him and the two French women he was accompanying. The two women were later released but Mr.P was arrested and charged with attempted theft. He was supposed to have put his hands in the bag of an unknown woman, a woman who could not be produced. The officers also called him a 'pimp', because he was with the two French women. At the time of his arrest he had only one pound fifty on him.

Fortunately the community group who had organised the exchange acted quickly on Mr.P's behalf, by getting the support of other community groups as well as Newham Monitoring Project. Mr.P was acquitted of all charges against him when the case was eventually heard in court.

These are some of a very small number of police harassment cases in which black people were successful in defending themselves. In a large number of cases, they are found guilty because of falsified police evidence, and a legal system which all too readily accepts such evidence.

FASCISM IN NEWHAM

1986 represents a year of consolidation, organisation and activity for Newham Anti-Fascist Action, formed in 1985 to specifically combat neo-fascist activity in the borough. The Project's work in this field involved playing an active part in the campaigning work of Newham AFA, servicing and participating in its activities and helping to disseminate anti-fascist literature. We regard our links with Newham AFA as invaluable for a number of reasons:

- (a) Newham has historically been an area with a high level of fascist activity stretching back into the late 1960's and early 1970's. Electoral groups like the National Front, exploiting the very real fears of local people over unemployment, bad housing etc and feeding on the deep-rooted historical racism in the area, have always done relatively well at the 1983 General Elections the National Front polled near 2000 votes in the three local constituencies. We feel it important that this direct and more physical manifestation of racism, organised fascist activity is challenged both ideologically and politically and, where it rears its ugly head in public, physically through mass community opposition.
- (b) A number of our cases reveal some degree of participation in attacks by known local fascists. A number of social centres, schools and community places around which racist attacks have taken place also happen to be precisely those places known to be frequented by members of fascist organisations or individuals under the influence of fascist ideology.
- (c) The monitoring of local fascists and fascist activity in the borough supplies us with a useful reference point to provide information to voluntary, statutory and community groups, the media etc as and when necessary. An example of how useful this monitoring can be was revealed when the NF's local organiser hired a local school under a false name. Detailed information on local fascists passed to the Council will hopefully ensure that this will not occur again.

We also firmly believe that maximum vigilance is required when dealing with fascism as it is a force capable of developing overnight and needs to be tackled positively and effectively, whilst it is still small. In recognising that the fight against racism is inseparable from that against fascism (for after all, there is no academic distinction between them, for they both perpetrate, racist attacks against black people) we need to fight both fronts simultaneously.

We accordingly prioritised our anti-fascist work in 1986 in the following way:

Education

This involves disseminating anti-racist anti-fascist literature as widely as possible around the borough and helping to promote the aims and objectives of Newham AFA.

Organising debates on contemporary racism and fascism with schools, youth-clubs and local and national organisations.

Campaigning and Mobilisation

This involved giving support to initiatives launched by Newham AFA. The Project helped mobilise local support for initiatives mounted by Newham AFA in opposing fascist activity locally and London wide, in particular, support for the first ever national march on Remembrance Sunday to remember the victims of racism and fascism, of yesteryear and the present.

Fascist activity in Newham over the last year has taken the form of occasional paper sales in High Street North and at West Ham FC, trouble around certain pubs and wine bars and in some cases evidence suggests organised attacks around schools and homes in the South East area of the borough. With the approach of a General Election in 1987, we expect these activities to intensify. Indeed recent statements by leading East London NF members that "if we want aggro we go to Newham", the presence in Monmouth Road, E6, of leading NF member Ian Anderson and the fact that the main splinter group in the NF today, the NF Support Group is predominantly Newham and Essex based all give us cause for concern. It is hoped that our work can complement that of Newham AFA in combating the spread of racist and fascist ideology amongst white working class youths and in schools and youth clubs.

BALANCE SHEET AS AT 31 MARCH 1986

31 MAY
1985

CURRENT ASSETS

Refunds receiveable	10,248	-
Debtors and Prepayments	6,815	184
Cash at Bank and in Hand	39,199	30,546
	56,262	30,730

CURRENT LIABILITIES

Creditors and Accrued Expenses	43,444	13,183
Specified Revenue Funding	11,100	13,000
	54,544	26,183

NET CURRENT ASSETS	1,718	4,547

REPRESENTED BY:

INCOME AND EXPENDITURE ACCOUNT

Surplus/(Deficit) brought forward	4,547	(6,408)
(Deficit)/Surplus for the period	(2,829)	10,955
	1,718	4,547

INCOME AND EXPENDITURE ACCOUNT

	1986	1985
INCOME		
Grant Funding	88,739	90,398
Transfer of specified funding	3,900	-
Other Income	1,238	43
	93,877	90,441
EXPENDITURE		
Salaires and NI	38,530	30,276
Administrative Services	1,070	2,862
Rent, Rates and Services	1,075	1,244
Repairs and Maintance	1,497	245
Insurance	163	612
Telephone	3,312	1,648
Stationery, Postage, Office		
Materials	5,810	2,330
Advertising and Publicity	1,913	1,344
Printing and Literature	4,746	3,359
Audit and Accountancy	920	425
Legal Fees	-	270
Hall Hire and Conferences	422	207
Motor, Travel and Subsistence		
Expenses	4,780	4,784
Volunteer's Expenses	1,381	3,587
Bank Charges and Other Expenses	709	679
Equiupment Purchased	23,325	12,134
Cash Funds Stolen	-	480
Report Expenses	3,914	-
Loss on Cancelled orders	1,139	-
	94,706	66,486
	(829)	23,955
LESS: PROVISION FOR SPECIFIED		
REVENUE FUNDING	2,000	13,000
(Deficit)/Surplus for the period	(2,829)	10,955